

Measuring the intention-behavior gap in service failure and recovery: the moderating roles of failure severity and service recovery satisfaction

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Abstract

Purpose – The intention-behavior gap that occurs when one's actions do not align with their intentions has been the topic of interest of many researchers. However, the effects of the various constructs that influence the intention-behavior gap in service failure and recovery remain under-explored to date. To fill this gap, this study aims to examine the relationship between switching intention (i.e. intention) and customer exit (i.e. behavior) and the moderating roles of failure severity and service recovery satisfaction.

Design/methodology/approach – To test the proposed hypotheses, the authors used a longitudinal panel involving 821 customers who actually experienced a service failure and recovery in 38 fitness centers in Brazil. The data analysis is composed of logistic regression and cross-tabulation.

Findings – The results confirmed the significant role of switching intention on customer exit and the moderating effect of failure severity (but not service recovery satisfaction) in the relationship between switching intention and customer exit. Most of all, switching intention had low explanatory power for customer exit, confirming the presence of the intention-behavior gap. The authors further identified a weaker presence of the intention-behavior gap for female (vs male) customers and for those who experienced process failure (vs outcome failure).

Research limitations/implications – Although the authors confirmed the intention-behavior gap, the biggest proportion of the variance remains unexplained. Thus, it is important to explore the roles of other possible drivers, moderators and mediators.

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Practical implications – As switching intention is not a strong predictor of customer exit, managers should not assume that those who appear to be on the verge of switching will immediately exit the service provider.

Originality/value – As researchers question the explanatory power of intention for actual behavior, this paper confirms that there is an intention-behavior gap in service failure and recovery. Moreover, given that most researchers have focused on the positive outcomes of service recovery efforts, such as customer loyalty and commitment, studying negative outcomes, including switching intention and customer exit, is a key contribution of this research.

Keywords Intention-behavior gap, Switching intention, Customer exit, Failure severity, Service recovery satisfaction, Complaint satisfaction

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

The theory of reasoned action (Fishbein, 1980; Fishbein and Ajzen, 1975) and theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1985, 1991) posit that intention plays a key role in predicting actual behavior. This framework has been consistently applied in social science studies, including research in consumer behavior (Blut and Wang, 2020; Ghasrodashti, 2018; Liu *et al.*, 2017; Watson *et al.*, 2015). Despite its extensive application, however, the relationship between intention and behavior, or more specifically, the power of intention to predict behavior, has been constantly questioned. Based on a meta-analysis encompassing 422 studies, Sheeran (2002) pointed out that, on average, 28% of variance in behavior is attributed to intention; in other words, a change in intention does not necessarily guarantee changes in behavior such that a goal set is not always a goal accomplished. Although the amount of variance explained for behavior by intention seems mediocre, a coefficient of correlation (r) between intention and behavior translates into 0.53, indicating a relatively large correlation between the two variables (Funder and Ozer, 2019), given that the mean meta-analytic correlation is 0.24 in marketing (Eisend, 2015) and 0.19 in social/personality psychology (Gignac and Szodorai, 2016). Considering that several variables might be responsible for a particular phenomenon of interest, one variable explaining more than one-fourth of the variance is powerful (Eisend, 2015). Nevertheless, a lack of explanatory power of intention for behavior, termed the intention-behavior gap, represents the irrevocable discrepancy between expressing an intention to engage in a behavior and actually engaging in it (Sheeran, 2002).

The potential existence of an intention-behavior gap and the inconsistent academic evidence for this phenomenon (Webb and Sheeran, 2006) have often led to the development of irrelevant managerial implications. While consumer's self-reported intentions are widely used in academic research due to their easy-to-collect nature as proxy behaviors (Chandon *et al.*, 2005), customer's intentions often fail to correctly predict customer's future behaviors. To this end, Hulland and Houston (2021) called for research to close the intention-behavior gap in empirical investigations of marketing by explicitly measuring actual behaviors or by using indirect measurement of proxy behaviors.

In this research, we examine the relationship between customer's switching intention (SI) (i.e. intention) and customer exit (i.e. behavior) in the context of service failure and service recovery. In the service industry, service failures are common, frequent and often unavoidable. In response to inconveniences caused by a service failure, firms offer service recovery to restore customer satisfaction (Nikbin and Hyun, 2015). However, not all firms are successful in carrying out service recovery, and as such, the quality of the service recovery determines the service recovery satisfaction (SRS) (Smith *et al.*, 1999), which leads to customer's positive responses to service providers. Despite this, the literature on service

marketing is replete with research focusing on the role of service recovery in enhancing customer maintenance than in reducing customer defection (Gummerus *et al.*, 2017; Piha and Avlonitis, 2015). This is an important gap because identifying the root causes of customer defection is as important as, if not more important than understanding the causes of customer maintenance (Reichheld, 1996).

One notable exception is Wirtz *et al.* (2014), who made an important distinction between SI and switching behavior and further identified different drivers for each in contractual service settings. According to Wirtz *et al.* (2014), the core difference between SI and switching behavior is whether the customers respond to a hypothetical situation about switching or actually carry out their actions. Based on construal level theory, they argued that outcome-related variables such as price, quality and monetary switching costs affect SI more because when individuals feel an event is psychologically distant (e.g. when the event is hypothetical), they place higher importance on the desirability factors (i.e. outcome). On the other hand, process-related variables, such as effort, time and nonmonetary switching costs affect switching behavior more because when people feel an event is psychologically near (e.g. when it is going to happen in the immediate future), they focus on the feasibility factors (i.e. procedure). Therefore, SI and switching behavior are driven by a qualitatively different set of variables.

Similar to Wirtz *et al.* (2014), Naumann *et al.* (2010) focused on identifying the differing motives for SI and actual switching behavior and conducted their investigation in the facility management service domain in B2B. However, even though both Wirtz *et al.* (2014) and Naumann *et al.* (2010) meaningfully examined the difference between SI and switching behavior, they did not focus on the context of service failure and service recovery but on the general context of service. Other than these studies, there is a lack of research that empirically examined the relationship between SI and switching behavior. Most of the existing studies have limitedly focused on identifying the antecedents for either SI (Haenlein and Kaplan, 2012; Walsh *et al.*, 2006) or switching behavior (Haj-Salem and Chebat, 2014; Kim, 2021) to curb customer defection.

Moreover, many studies have methodological shortcomings. For instance, SI is measured using a single-item scale (Naumann *et al.*, 2010; Walsh *et al.*, 2006; Wirtz *et al.*, 2014). Single-item scales are often as reliable (Bergkvist, 2015; Bergkvist and Rossiter, 2007) and predictive (Diamantopoulos *et al.*, 2012) as multi-item scales for unidimensional and unambiguous constructs and are sometimes the only feasible option for scholars who conduct field research, considering that customers in real-world settings are often reluctant to respond to lengthy survey instruments (Cialdini, 2009; Otterbring *et al.*, 2022). However, multi-item scales outperform single-item scales with their increased reliability and construct validity (DeVellis, 2003). Therefore, the use of multi-item scales is preferred to single-item scales in most empirical settings (Diamantopoulos *et al.*, 2012). In addition, switching behavior is often measured by self-report (Kim, 2021; Wirtz *et al.*, 2014) rather than capturing actual customer behavior explicitly, as suggested by Hulland and Houston (2021). Table 1 presents a chronological summary of existing literature in the service context that examined the relationship between SI and customer exit, categorized by industry, research context, measures of SI and customer exit, as well as key findings.

In light of the lack of studies examining the relationship between SI and actual switching behavior in a service failure and recovery, questions needing deeper investigation arise:

- Q1. What is the predictive power of SI on customer exit in the context of service failure and recovery?

References (ordered chronologically)	Industry	Context	Measure of switching intention	Measure of customer exit	Key findings
Walsh <i>et al.</i> (2006)	Power service and B2B	General service	Yes, single-item scale in a survey	No	Customer satisfaction (but not corporate reputation) is negatively associated with switching intention
Naumann <i>et al.</i> (2010)	Facility management service and B2B	General service	Yes, single-item scale in a survey but measured as the likelihood of renewing the service contract (opposite of switching intention)	Yes, observed from a database	Motives for switching intention are different from actual reasons for customer exit
Haenlein and Kaplan (2012)	Telecommunication service and B2C	General service	Yes, multi-item scale in a survey	No	High levels of alternative attractiveness and voice intention, respectively, lead to higher switching intention
Haj-Salem and Chebat (2014)	Telecommunication service and B2C	Service failure and recovery	No	Yes, observed from a database but measured as loyalty behavior (opposite of customer exit)	Outward negative emotions (e.g. anger) due to negative switching costs reduce loyalty (or increase customer exit), while inward negative emotions (e.g. sadness, guilt or regret) due to positive switching costs increase loyalty (or reduce customer exit)
Wirtz <i>et al.</i> (2014)	Contractual service and B2C	General service	Yes, single-item scale in a survey	Yes, self-reported in a survey	Switching intention is driven by a qualitatively different set of variables than customer exit
Kim (2021)	Fitness center and B2C	General service	No	Yes, self-reported in a survey	While push and pull effects positively predict customer exit, mooring effects negatively predict customer exit
Our study	Fitness center and B2C	Service failure and recovery	Yes, multi-item scale in a survey	Yes, observed from a database	Switching intention is not a powerful predictor of customer exit, and gender and the type of failure (process vs outcome) are important considerations in this relationship

Source: Authors

Table 1.
Summary review of
the literature

Do failure severity (FS) and SRS moderate the relationship between SI and customer exit? Does the SI-behavior gap indeed exist, and if so, what is the magnitude of it? Finally, will the customer characteristic of gender (female vs male) and the type of service failure experienced (outcome failure vs process failure) have any influence on the presence of a SI-behavior gap?

To answer these research questions, we approached and used actual customers who had experienced a service failure and filed a formal complaint as research subjects in a real service setting, asking them to rate FS, satisfaction with service recovery and SI and registering their actual customer exit behavior. This method offers enhanced ecological validity (Keidser *et al.*, 2020) compared to self-reported measures of switching behavior and allows the collection of longitudinal data. We also recorded the gender of respondents and the type of failure they experienced.

We chose the fitness center industry as a research context because it is a sector where customer churn commonly occurs, and frequent interactions between customers and employees are likely (León-Quismondo *et al.*, 2020), increasing the chances of service failure and the need for service recovery. The fitness industry presents a considerable scale all over the world. The market size accounts for US\$96.7bn, encompassing 210,000 fitness clubs and 184 million members worldwide (Wellness Creative Co, 2022). Moreover, there is severe competition among businesses in this industry as most of them are small firms, implying that customers have many alternatives. Even if customer retention is a primary interest among the managers of fitness centers to achieve long-term profitability and survival (Kim and Byon, 2021), little academic evidence exists to offer managers meaningful guidance to manage customer complaints.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. The next section presents the theoretical framework and the development of the hypotheses. Then come sections devoted to explaining the research design, presenting the findings and describing the academic and managerial contributions. Finally, study limitations and suggestions for future research are discussed.

Theoretical framework and hypothesis development

This section reviews the concepts of SI, customer exit and the intention-behavior gap, as well as FS and SRS, which are the building blocks of the proposed hypotheses. In examining the primary relationship between SI (i.e. intention) and customer exit (i.e. behavior) in the domain of service failure and recovery, we propose FS and SRS as moderators that influence the relationship between the two focal variables, given their relevance to the context of service failure and recovery.

Switching intention and customer exit

SI and customer exit (i.e. switching behavior or customer defection) are closely related concepts. The first represents the customer's willingness to switch service providers, while the second reflects the actual behavior of switching providers (Wirtz *et al.*, 2014). SI is attitudinal, whereas customer exit is behavioral. In the empirical literature, SI, a central concept in relationship marketing theory (Casielles *et al.*, 2010; Miller *et al.*, 2000), is typically measured using a single item or a categorical response option (i.e. low and high; e.g. Ahmad, 2002; Capraro *et al.*, 2003; Santonen, 2007; Wirtz *et al.*, 2014). Even if SI is a consequence of customer dissatisfaction after a service provider's poor performance (Han *et al.*, 2011; Yu *et al.*, 2014), improving service quality after a failure or even a satisfactory service recovery can be insufficient to restore customer trust toward the company and decrease SI (Ranaweera and Prabhu, 2003).

Customer exit, on the other hand, occurs when customers forsake one provider for another, completely or partially. The service marketing literature has identified several factors associated with customer exit, including knowledge about alternative providers (Capraro *et al.*, 2003), customer characteristics and service features (Santonen, 2007; Trubik and Smith, 2000) and unsatisfactory service recovery (Ahmad, 2002). The seminal article by Keaveney (1995) on customer exit identified eight antecedents: pricing, inconvenience, core service failure, service encounter failures, response to service failure, competition, ethical problems and involuntary switching.

The positive relationship between intention and behavior has been generally established in empirical studies (De Cannière *et al.*, 2010; Huang *et al.*, 2021), based on the logic of the theory of reasoned action (Fishbein, 1980; Fishbein and Ajzen, 1975) and the theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1985, 1991). However, researchers have not found the relationship between the two variables to be consistently strong (Carrington *et al.*, 2014; Sheeran, 2002). Some authors have questioned the strength of intention in driving behavior, with existing evidence demonstrating a low to medium explanatory power of intention for behavior (Hulland and Houston, 2021; Sheeran, 2002; Webb and Sheeran, 2006).

If intentions do not always translate into behaviors, it is crucial to understand the reasons why this happens (Carrington *et al.*, 2014; Wirtz *et al.*, 2014). Among the various factors influencing the relationship between SI and customer exit, we focus on FS and SRS as focal phenomena which serve as moderators in the relationship between SI and customer exit.

Failure severity

Failure severity is the magnitude of loss experienced by a customer due to errors in service delivery (Choi and Choi, 2014; Hess *et al.*, 2003; Weun *et al.*, 2004). Service failures vary in severity depending on the problem created and the customer's perception (Cho *et al.*, 2017). Weun *et al.* (2004) argued that FS influences the evaluation of service recovery and customers' commitment to stay with the provider. Similarly, McQuilken and Robertson (2011) described FS as a critical factor linked to SI.

Failure severity depends on an individual's subjective perceptions (Smith *et al.*, 1999; Swanson and Hsu, 2011). In general, the more severe or intense the error, the higher the loss perceived by the customer (Choi and Choi, 2014; de Matos *et al.*, 2012; Kim and Ulgado, 2012; Nikbin and Hyun, 2015). A failure that is perceived to be very severe tends to be negatively linked to satisfaction, trust, and consequently repurchase behavior (Cho *et al.*, 2017; de Matos *et al.*, 2009; Magnini *et al.*, 2007; Shin *et al.*, 2016). Failures considered to be more severe present greater difficulties for recovery (Chuang *et al.*, 2012; Ma *et al.*, 2020) and, therefore, entail a greater probability of SI and behavior (Swanson and Hsu, 2011).

Service recovery satisfaction

Organizations committed to customer loyalty seek to recover customers' losses to regain their satisfaction. Therefore, they engage in service recovery, referring to the service provider's response to a complaint made by a customer who experienced a failure (Brown *et al.*, 1996; Smith *et al.*, 1999). The activities developed by companies and employees to compensate customers for their losses in the form of service recovery have been a strategic issue in the service literature (Choi and Choi, 2014; Smith *et al.*, 1999). The recovery process represents a bundle of resources geared toward gathering complaints, fixing problems, changing the negative perception and attitude of dissatisfied consumers affected by a service failure (Casielles *et al.*, 2009; Smith *et al.*, 1999) and bringing them back to the state of satisfaction with the organization and its services (Collie *et al.*, 2000).

Customer satisfaction with service recovery is an affective, subjective response which indicates the extent to which a consumer perceives that the performance of the organization in solving the failure is adequate (Hess *et al.*, 2003; Nikbin and Hyun, 2015). If the service provider makes no effort to recover, adverse responses may be triggered, such as irritation, anger and frustration (Choi and Choi, 2014; McColl-Kennedy and Sparks, 2003). When service recovery is unsatisfactory, a double deviation arises (Basso and Pizzutti, 2016; Tripp and Grégoire, 2011), in which customers experience service failure twice in a row: “the initial service failure and the failed service recovery” (Casado *et al.*, 2011, p. 41).

On the other hand, a successful service recovery leads to customer retention, a key factor in business survival (McCollough *et al.*, 2000). The positive influence of successful complaint handling in customer evaluation is explained by the service recovery paradox (de Matos *et al.*, 2007; Hocutt *et al.*, 2006; Maxham and Netemeyer, 2002), which describes a situation in which a customer’s postfailure satisfaction followed by an effective service recovery exceeds prefailure satisfaction without experiencing a service failure (McCollough and Bharadwaj, 1992). The service recovery paradox indicates the critical role of effective service recovery in restoring the customer’s satisfaction after a service failure. According to the meta-analysis result on service recovery paradox, the positive effect of the service recovery paradox on customer satisfaction is evident, even if its impact on various customer responses such as repurchase intention and word-of-mouth intention is inconclusive (de Matos *et al.*, 2007).

Empirical research on the relationship between SRS and customer exit so far presents mixed findings. For instance, Chebat *et al.* (2011) show that more satisfied customers with service recovery are less likely to exit, while Bolton and Bronkhorst (1995) demonstrate those who expressed that they were “very satisfied” with the service recovery still choose to exit. Despite the conflicting results, the general consensus in the literature is that there is a positive influence of satisfaction with service recovery in preventing customer exit. Customer satisfaction with the firm’s service recovery has been shown to increase positive customer intentions, such as positive word-of-mouth intention (Hocutt *et al.*, 2006) and reduce negative customer intentions, such as negative word-of-mouth intention (Balaji *et al.*, 2017) and SI (Zeithaml *et al.*, 2017). Those who are satisfied with a service recovery may even become loyal to the company (Blodgett *et al.*, 1997; Choi and Choi, 2014; de Matos *et al.*, 2009).

Moderating roles of failure severity and service recovery satisfaction

Intention is a desire to perform any behavior or to achieve a goal. In the literature, it is typically measured in the form of “I intend to do X” (Triandis, 1980). In this sense, intentions capture the motivational states that influence behaviors. The marketing literature is replete with studies measuring intention as the dependent variable, such as purchase intention (Arli *et al.*, 2018; Olson, 2013) and word-of-mouth intention (Hocutt *et al.*, 2006). Papers examining intentions as the main, key drivers of behavior are also plentiful (Blut and Wang, 2020; Huang *et al.*, 2021; Watson *et al.*, 2015). However, some authors have questioned the strength of intention in driving behavior, and existing evidence demonstrate a low to medium explanatory power of intention for behavior (Hulland and Houston, 2021; Sheeran, 2002; Webb and Sheeran, 2006). If an intention-behavior gap exists, it is important to understand why this happens (Carrington *et al.*, 2014; Wirtz *et al.*, 2014).

The enactment of a behavior requires the simultaneous occurrence of three factors: motivation, ability and triggers (Fogg, 2009). Motivation is the strength of the desire to perform the target behavior, ability is the individual’s capacity to perform the behavior and a trigger is the event that causes the behavior to start. Webb and Sheeran (2006)

present the following three factors to explain the failure to turn intentions into behaviors: failure to get started, failure to keep the goal on track and failure to bring the goal to a successful close.

Factors that moderate the relationship between intention and behavior, namely, conceptual factors, measurement features and study characteristics, also exist (Webb and Sheeran, 2006). Conceptual factors are theoretical variables that affect how well intention predicts behavior, measurement features relate to the time interval between measuring the intention and the behavior and whether the intention and behavior were objectively measured, and study characteristics refer to the type of samples (e.g. student vs nonstudent) and the effect sizes. Therefore, the positive relationship between SI and customer exit we expect can be influenced by various moderators.

In this study, we consider FS and SRS as conceptual moderators (Webb and Sheeran, 2006), considering their relevance to the context of service failure and recovery. Although SI may directly predict customer exit, it is also likely that the relationship between SI and customer exit is moderated by FS. Typically, a severe service failure enhances a customer's perception of loss (Choi and Choi, 2014; de Matos *et al.*, 2012; Kim and Ulgado, 2012; Nikbin and Hyun, 2015), leading to negative customer reactions toward the service provider (Cho *et al.*, 2017; de Matos *et al.*, 2009; Magnini *et al.*, 2007; Shin *et al.*, 2016). For instance, Swanson and Hsu (2011) found that the greater the magnitude of failure, the greater the likelihood of customer's negative word-of-mouth about the service organization.

Even if the role of FS has not been investigated in the relationship between SI and customer exit in the literature, it is likely that FS further promotes the positive effect of SI on customer exit given the nature of high FS leading to strong negative customer reactions. Therefore, we expect that the more severe the service failure is, the stronger the positive relationship between the SI and customer exit will be. Thus, we propose:

- H1.* Failure severity enhances the positive relationship between switching intention and customer exit.

Moreover, we expect that SRS will serve as a moderator in the relationship between SI and customer exit. Service recovery satisfaction restores the state of satisfaction with the firm after a service failure (Collie *et al.*, 2000) since the firm makes an investment in amending their service failures (Casielles *et al.*, 2009; Smith *et al.*, 1999). The relationship management literature well establishes the positive associations between firms' relationship investments and customer's patronage behaviors (Hennig-Thurau *et al.*, 2002; Palmatier *et al.*, 2009). However, the moderating role of SRS in the relationship between SI and customer exit has not been explored.

Considering that the goal of service recovery is to restore customer satisfaction by offering a high-quality service recovery that meets the customer's expectation following service failure (Nikbin and Hyun, 2015), SRS is likely to attenuate the positive relationship between SI and customer exit, such that the higher the SRS, the weaker the positive relationship between SI and customer exit will be. This leads to:

- H2.* Service recovery satisfaction attenuates the positive relationship between switching intention and customer exit.

Figure 1 represents the conceptual model. The solid lines represent the direct effects of SI, FS and SRS on customer exit, and the dashed lines indicate the hypothesized moderating roles of FS (*H1*) and SRS (*H2*) on the relationship between SI and customer exit.

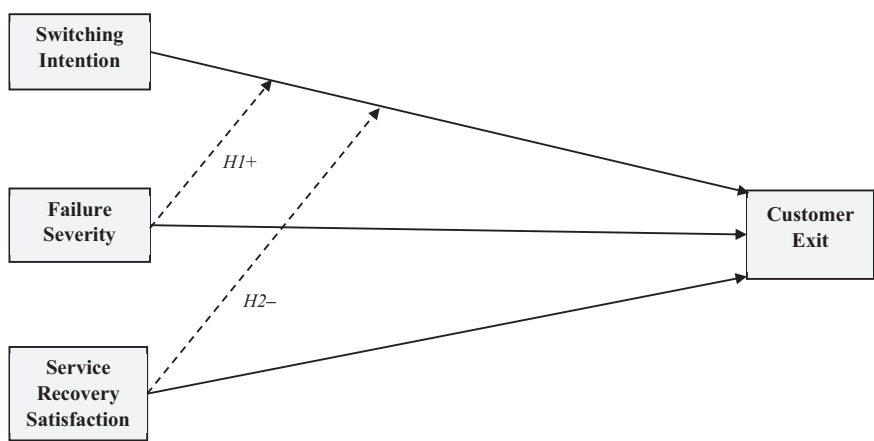


Figure 1.
Conceptual model

Source: Authors

Research design

The data collection was conducted in two stages. In the first stage, a questionnaire was developed and administered to 1,500 customers in 38 gyms located in a total of 17 cities across six Brazilian states. Brazil makes up the second largest fitness market in the world, with 34,509 fitness centers (the largest market is the USA with 38,477 fitness centers) and has the fourth-largest number of customers with 9.6 million [ACAD Brasil (Associação Brasileira de Academias), 2018].

All the 38 gyms involved in this research are owned by single family and targeted toward similar markets, primarily serving middle-class customers. The years each gym was established ranged from 1977 to 2017. Since the ownership structure is family-owned, none had a prominent leadership position among the 38 gym locations, with each gym having its own market presence. A full profile of each gym can be found in the [Appendix](#).

The sampling process was carried out in a similar manner in every gym. The interviewees were selected by convenience based on their service failure and formal complaint experience. Owing to the diversified samples of customers from the 38 different gym locations, we obtained a representative sample of gym goers in terms of sociodemographic characteristics, such as gender, educational level, income and marital status.

The questionnaire included 17 items: 11 items to measure the main constructs, one item each for failure type and complaint channel and four items for customers' profile. The four items on SI were adapted from [Malhotra and Malhotra \(2013\)](#). The three items for FS were adapted from [Wang et al. \(2011\)](#). Finally, SRS was measured using four items developed by [Blodgett et al. \(1997\)](#).

In the second step, three to four months after the first step was completed, a follow-up data collection was conducted to measure customer exit by identifying those who maintained (no exit; coded 0) and those who had discontinued (exit; coded 1) their membership. This method represented an explicit measurement of behavior ([Hulland and Houston, 2021](#)) and reduced common method variance ([Podsakoff et al., 2003, 2012](#)).

We conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to check the validity and reliability of the constructs. Next, to test the moderating effects of FS and SRS, we performed a logistic

regression using the factor scores (Hair *et al.*, 2006). This analysis method was chosen due to the binary nature of the dependent variable (Finney and DiStefano, 2006; Hair *et al.*, 2012), which strongly violates the normality assumption. Finally, we performed a cross-tabulation between SI and customer exit to examine the magnitude of the intention-behavior gap in the current research context. We used AMOS 27 for CFA and SPSS 27 to calculate the logistic regression and cross-tabulation.

Findings

Out of the 1,500 questionnaires sent in the first step, 1,164 were returned (77.6% response rate). After the follow-up identification of customer exit in the second step, the sample size was 915. In a preliminary analysis, we checked for the presence of multivariate outliers by estimating the Mahalanobis Distance. Accordingly, 94 multivariate outliers with a significance level equal to or smaller than 0.001 were excluded from the data set (Hair *et al.*, 2006). The final sample size was 821, comprised of 61.5% female and 38.5% male. For marital status, 45.6% were single, 43.2% married, 5.5% divorced and 5.7% of other marital status. As for educational level, 44.0% had a college degree and 31.1% had a graduate degree. Regarding monthly income, 11.6% earned more than US\$3,400 (R\$17,340 in Brazilian currency), 25.0% earned between US\$1,700 (R\$8,670) and US\$3,400 (R\$17,340) and the rest earned less than US\$1,700 (R\$8,670).

When it comes to membership length, 30% had been members for more than four years, followed by 28.1% for less than one year, 22.38% for 1–2 years and 19.52% for 2–4 years. Most respondents (52.38%) had an annual membership, 31.43% a monthly membership, 10.48% a biannual membership and 5.71% had other membership status. The reported service failures were classified into two types: outcome failures (i.e. failures related to what was delivered in services, including lack of or broken equipment and infrastructure, such as sports rooms, lockers, showers and swimming pools; 71.7%) and process failures (i.e. failures related to how service was delivered including poor treatment by instructors and staff; 28.3%). Finally, 79.0% of the complaints were made personally, 12.1% via a complaint box and the remaining 8.9% were made in other ways.

Initially, we performed a CFA to check the item loadings (Table 2) and the validity and reliability of the constructs (Table 3). Confirming reliability, all constructs achieved Cronbach's Alpha (α) and composite reliability (CR) above 0.7. Convergent validity was confirmed as all the average variance extracted (AVE) values are greater than 0.5, and all loadings, except for one (fs3), were significant and greater than 0.7 (Hair *et al.*, 2006, 2021). Finally, discriminant validity was confirmed using the Fornell–Larcker criterion (Fornell and Larcker, 1981); all the correlations between the constructs are smaller than the square root of the AVE, as displayed in the main diagonal of the right panel of Table 3.

Attesting the goodness of fit of the measurement model (Hair *et al.*, 2006; Kline, 2016), the absolute index (GFI = 0.954), the comparative indices (CFI = 0.980, TLI = 0.973) and the parsimony indices (PCFI = 0.730, PNFI = 0.727) were all above the minimum threshold and RMSEA was 0.070, below the upper limit.

Hypothesis testing

We performed a logistic regression to evaluate the direct effects of SI, FS and SRS on customer exit and the moderating effects of FS and SRS in the relationship between SI and customer exit.

The unstandardized coefficients, presented in Table 4, confirm the positive associations between SI and customer exit ($\beta = 0.259$, $p = 0.001$) and between FS customer exit ($\beta = 0.262$, $p = 0.001$). Service recovery satisfaction, on the other hand, is negatively associated

Table 2.
Confirmatory factor
analysis (CFA) –
coefficients

Scale/items ^a	Loading
<i>Failure severity (FS)</i>	
The failure caused me financial problems. (fs1)	0.773
The failure caused me health damage. (fs2)	0.811
My daily life was hampered due to failure. (fs3)	0.636
<i>Switching intention (SI)</i>	
I'm prone to switch fitness center (si1)	0.937
I've been looking for information about other fitness centers. (si2)	0.911
After the failure, my desire to switch fitness center increased. (si3)	0.944
I will certainly switch fitness center. (si4)	0.934
<i>Service recovery satisfaction (SRS)</i>	
In general terms, I was satisfied with the complaint handling. (srs1)	0.912
I was satisfied with the compensation I received. (srs2)	0.866
I was pleased with the way I was treated. (srs3)	0.890
I was satisfied with complaint handling system. (srs4)	0.902
Note: ^a Anchored by strongly disagree (1) to strongly agree (7)	
Source: Research data	

Table 3.
Validity and
reliability

Construct	Cronbach's alpha	Composite reliability (CR)	Average variance extracted (AVE)	FS	SI	SRS
Failure severity (FS)	0.778	0.787	0.554	0.744		
Switching intention (SI)	0.963	0.963	0.868	0.426	0.932	
Service recovery satisfaction (SRS)	0.940	0.934	0.779	0.312	0.592	0.883
Source: Research data						

Table 4.
Logistic regression:
effects on customer
exit

DV	IV	Coefficient	Wald	Sig.
Customer exit	Switching intention (SI)	0.259	23.93	0.001
Customer exit	Failure severity (FS)	0.262	10.135	0.001
Customer exit	Service recovery satisfaction (SRS)	−0.137	5.666	0.001
Customer exit	FS * SI	0.078	4.027	0.045
R^2	Cox-Snell 0.171	Nagelkerke	0.233	
Source: Research data				

with customer exit ($\beta = -0.137, p = 0.001$). Furthermore, the relationship between SI and customer exit is moderated by FS, as indicated by the significant interaction term between SI and FS on customer exit ($\beta = 0.78; p = 0.045$); that is, the more severe the failure, the stronger the positive relationship between SI and customer exit, confirming *H1*. On the other hand, SRS did not have a moderating effect, which led to the exclusion of the interaction term between SI and SRS on customer exit, and consequently the rejection of *H2*. The rejection of *H2* calls for further investigation. Even if SRS had a direct negative association

with customer exit, it did not serve as a moderator between SI and customer exit. This may be attributable to the strong presence of the service recovery paradox; the enhanced postrecovery satisfaction itself served as a buffer to customer exit, not necessarily in combination with SI.

When all the independent variables are included in the model, the Cox–Snell R^2 and Nagelkerke R^2 were 0.171 and 0.233, respectively, explaining one-fifth of the variance in customer exit by the combination of the independent variables. Even though these values appear to be small, this is in line with [Gray et al. \(2017\)](#), who identified a weak yet positive relationship between SI and actual switching behavior.

Examination of the switching intention-behavior gap

While the existence of the positive relationship between SI and customer exit has been established in this study, the magnitude of the SI-behavior gap has not been attested. Thus, we cross-tabulated SI and customer exit. Since SI is a continuous variable, first, the composite variable of SI was split into three groups using the visual binning option in SPSS ([Meyers et al., 2013](#)). The result showed 314, 243 and 264 participants, who were categorized into low (mean: ≤ 1), medium (mean: 1.1–3.75) and high (mean: ≥ 3.76) groups, respectively. Cross-tabulation between SI and customer exit was performed next. The Pearson chi-square value (χ^2) was 7.133, and the p -value was 0.028, rejecting the null hypothesis, concluding that there is a significant association between SI and customer exit.

The cross-tabulation results ([Table 5](#)) revealed that 148 (56.1%) out of 264 participants who reported high SI did not exit, while 113 participants (36.0%) out of 314 who reported low SI and 80 participants (32.9%) out of 243 who reported medium SI exited. Based on these findings, we observed the intention-behavior gap in the two groups of participants, those with high SI and those with low and medium SI. In other words, customers who indicated high SI did not exit, while customers who indicated low and medium SI ended up exiting. To further determine which categories are major contributors to the significant chi-square value, standardized and adjusted residuals were calculated. Standardized residuals with an absolute value ≥ 2 indicate major contributors to significant chi-square analyses. The highest values contribute more to the Chi-square statistic, while the signs show a smaller (negative) or greater (positive) number in that cell than expected ([Hinkle et al., 1994](#); see also [Otterbring et al., 2013](#)). If the standardized residuals do not offer strong evidence of contributions to the chi-square statistic, a more effective investigation can be conducted

Switching intention	Customer exit		Total
	No exit	Exit	
Low	200	113	313
%	63.9	36.1	100.0
Adjusted residual	0.7	−0.7	
Medium	163	80	243
%	67.1	32.9	100.0
Adjusted residual	1.8	−1.8	
High	148	116	264
%	56.1	43.9	100.0
Adjusted residual	−2.5	2.5	
Pearson χ^2	7.133	Significance	0.029

Source: Research data

Table 5.
Cross-tabulation:
switching intention
and customer exit

using the adjusted residuals (Haberman, 1973). The adjusted residual for high SI and customer behavior is 2.5, which means that the significant chi-square values are most likely driven by the overrepresentation of these people.

The gap between intention and behavior uncovered by the cross-tabulation analysis result, in addition to the low explanatory power of SI for customer exit as shown in the low R^2 value in the logistic regression, shows that intention is not a powerful predictor of behavior. This finding exemplifies the intention-behavior gap driven by those who fail to follow through on their intention, as observed by Sheeran (2002) and Webb and Sheeran (2006). This result, however, should be interpreted with care since the magnitude of the intention-behavior gap we uncovered in this study may pertain only to our particular research context of service failure and recovery in the fitness center industry in Brazil. Nevertheless, this result extends the findings of Wirtz *et al.* (2014) who identified the gap between the SI and switching behavior in a contractual service setting by demonstrating that the high SI group shows a different pattern of behavior from the low and medium SI groups when it comes to switching behavior.

Factors that explain a high SI yet no actual exit may include the unattractiveness of alternatives and customer inertia (de Mesquita and Urdan, 2019; Gray *et al.*, 2017) as well as customer's opportunistic behavior (Wirtz and McColl-Kennedy, 2010) by which customers take advantage of their high level of SI as a threat to seek compensation. On the other hand, seasonality may be a factor that explains the phenomenon of low SI with actual customer exit since the fitness industry is highly affected by it, such that the number of memberships significantly increases in certain seasons, such as New Year and summertime but decreases in other seasons (ACAD, 2018; Minton, 2003). Moreover, unexpected external factors such as customer's health issues and sudden move to another city might promote customer exit.

Another factor to consider in the SI-behavior gap is the influence of individuals' personal or psychological factors. For instance, Souiden *et al.* (2019) examined the influence of Japanese consumers' personality traits including self-confidence, aggressiveness and altruism on complaint behavior. Demographic characteristics, which are prominent individual difference variables, have been widely highlighted in the service literature (Wirtz *et al.*, 2014). Nevertheless, even if previous studies associated an individual's demographic characteristics with a customer's satisfaction with services (Sharma *et al.*, 2012), limited studies have linked them to customer evaluations of service recovery. Moreover, most studies have narrowly examined them as control variables, and therefore, the role of an individual's demographic characteristics on their evaluation of a service recovery has not been meaningfully investigated (Duffy *et al.*, 2006). This leads to a lack of attention to demographic variables despite their potential as useful market segmentation variables in service recovery (Lin, 2010).

The influence of gender in the switching intention-behavior gap

Among the demographic variables, gender is the most examined variable (Kim *et al.*, 2019; Sharma *et al.*, 2012). It has a direct influence on perceived service quality (Ganesan-Lim *et al.*, 2008), customer satisfaction (Kim *et al.*, 2019; Mittal and Kamakura, 2001) and customer loyalty (Patterson, 2007). Nevertheless, examination of the role of gender in the context of service recovery is scarce (Cambra-Fierro *et al.*, 2013; Duffy *et al.*, 2006) and only a few studies have investigated gender as a core research construct.

One of the most frequently used theories that explains and confirms the gender effect is gender socialization theory, which suggests that gender differences are instilled in the members of a culture from early childhood (Chodorow, 1978). Male and female customers differ in how they believe a service recovery should be carried out (Boshoff, 2012;

Daskin and Kasim, 2016). The evolutionary psychology literature generally points to females' emotionally sensitive nature to their environment and experiences compared to male counterparts (Bloise and Johnson, 2007). As a result, females are more emotionally expressive, such that they are more likely to cry and smile, as well as show more facial expressions (Fischer and LaFrance, 2015).

This translates into female customers' unique responses to the outcome of the service recovery compared to male customers. Cambra-Fierro *et al.* (2013) show that female customers place higher importance on perceived justice of the recovery outcome and thus have a higher expectation for service recovery than male customers (See also Lin, 2010). Male customers, on the other hand, might be more demanding and expect short-term results but tend to have lower expectations for service recovery than female customers. Given the higher expectations female customers have toward service recovery and their tendency to express their emotions more than male customers, we expect that the SI-behavior gap will be smaller for female customers than for male customers.

To this end, we performed a cross-tabulation between SI and customer exit by gender, expecting that female customers with high SI compared to male customers are more likely to exit. The three-way cross-tabulation results among gender, SI and customer exit (Table 6) revealed that among female customers, there is a significant association between SI and customer exit (Pearson $\chi^2 = 8.682$, $p = 0.013$), while there is no such association among male customers (Pearson $\chi^2 = 0.454$, $p = 0.797$). Close examination demonstrates that compared to female customers with low and medium SI (36.5% and 33.6%, respectively), those with high SI (48.8%) are more likely to exit. Moreover, when the rate of customer exit is compared for high SI customers between the two genders, female customers (48.8%) are more likely to exit than male customers (36.3%). Hence, women present a smaller SI-behavior gap than men.

Groups	Switching intention	Customer exit		Total
		No exit	Exit	
Male	Low	75	41	116
	%	64.7	35.3	100.0
	Adjusted residual	-0.2	0.2	
	Medium	66	31	97
	%	68.0	32.0	100.0
	Adjusted residual	0.7	-0.7	
	High	65	37	102
	%	63.7	36.3	100.0
	Adjusted residual	-0.4	0.4	
Pearson χ^2	0.454	Significance	0.797	
Female	Low	125	72	197
	%	63.5	36.5	100.0
	Adjusted residual	1.1	-1.1	
	Medium	97	49	146
	%	66.4	33.6	100.0
	Adjusted residual	1.8	-1.8	
	High	83	79	162
	%	51.2	48.8	100.0
	Adjusted residual	-2.9	2.9	
Pearson χ^2	8.682	Significance	0.013	

Source: Research data

Table 6.
Cross-tabulation:
gender, switching
intention and
customer exit

The adjusted residuals for women with high SI for both no exit (−2.9) and exit (2.9) are greater than the absolute value of 2, while no other standardized residuals in each cell represent major contributors. In sum, female consumers who expressed high (vs medium or low) SI are more likely to enact their actual exit behavior compared to male counterparts. These results reflect female customers' emphasis on perceived justice of the recovery outcome and higher expectation for service recovery compared to male customers (Cambra-Fierro *et al.*, 2013; Lin, 2010). It also is a testament to how gender is an important segmentation variable in service failure and recovery.

The influence of failure type in the switching intention-behavior gap

Two types of service failure have been documented in the service marketing literature: outcome and process (Maxham and Netemeyer, 2002; Smith *et al.*, 1999). Outcome failure relates to “what” was delivered and process failure concerns “how” the service was delivered (Smith and Bolton, 2002). Outcome failure occurs when the service organization fails to meet basic service needs or underperforms compared to the expected level of service, such as the unavailability of the reserved room at the hotel and leads to utilitarian or economic losses. On the other hand, process failure leads to symbolic or social losses because it involves problems that arise during service delivery, including rude service staff or long waiting time.

Depending on the type of service failure, customer reactions to the service provider differ significantly, even though the consensus is that individuals tend to react more negatively to process failures than to outcome failures during service encounters. For instance, Smith *et al.* (1999) found that process failure has a higher negative effect on satisfaction than outcome failure. Tsai *et al.* (2014) similarly found that process failure leads to not only greater negative reactions but also stronger feelings of betrayal compared to outcome failure. These findings are explained by the concept of attributional uncertainty, a feeling of confusion that occurs when an individual considers their current state of causal knowledge for identifying the controllability or stability of causes as inadequate (Edwards, 1998). Attributional uncertainty makes people less likely to exhibit strong reactions (Barrowclough and Hooley, 2003). As they tend to determine the cause for process failures more easily than for outcome failures (Chan *et al.*, 2007), it is likely that when customers experience process failure than outcome failure, they will demonstrate more negative reactions toward the service provider (Van Vaerenbergh *et al.*, 2014).

Translating this logic into the investigation of the relationship between SI and customer exit, we expect that customers who experienced a process failure and have high SI are more likely to exit compared to those who experienced an outcome failure. A three-way cross-tabulation among failure type, SI and customer exit was conducted. The results (Table 7) reveal that there is a significant association between SI and customer exit among the customers who experienced a process failure (Pearson $\chi^2 = 12.133$, $p = 0.002$) but no such association among those who experienced an outcome failure (Pearson $\chi^2 = 0.042$, $p = 0.979$). Close examination demonstrates that compared to customers who experienced a process failure and have low and medium SI (47.9% and 33.3%, respectively), those who have high SI (61.6%) are more likely to exit. Furthermore, when the rate of customer exit is compared for high SI customers based on the failure type, those who experienced a process failure (61.6%) were more likely to exit than those who experienced an outcome failure (33.3%). In this sense, those who experienced a process failure demonstrate a smaller SI-behavior gap than those who experienced an outcome failure. The analysis of adjusted residuals reinforces these findings. The adjusted residuals for procedure failure with high SI for both no exit (−3.1) and exit (3.1) are greater than the absolute value of 2.

					Moderating roles of failure severity
Groups	Switching intention	No exit	Customer exit Exit	Total	
Outcome failure	Low	162	78	240	1841
	%	67.5	32.5	100.0	
	Adjusted residual	0.1	−0.1		
	Medium	123	60	183	
	%	67.2	32.8	100.0	
	Adjusted residual	0.0	0.0		
	High	110	55	165	
	%	66.7	33.3	100.0	
Pearson χ^2	Adjusted residual	−0.2	0.2		Table 7. Cross-tabulation: failure type, switching intention and customer exit
	0.042	Significance	0.985		
Process failure	Low	38	35	73	
	%	52.1	47.9	100.0	
	Adjusted residual	0.4	−0.4		
	Medium	40	20	60	
	%	66.7	33.3	100.0	
	Adjusted residual	3.0	−3.0		
	High	38	61	99	
	%	38.4	61.6	100.0	
Pearson χ^2	Adjusted residual	−3.1	3.1		
	12.133	Significance	0.002		
Source: Research data					

These findings suggest that the way customers translate SI to exit behavior differs significantly based on the type of service failure experienced. Consistent with the previous evidence that individuals are more sensitive to process failures than outcome failures (Smith *et al.*, 1999; Tsai *et al.*, 2014) because the causes of process failure are easier to identify than the causes of outcome failure (Edwards, 1998), customers are more likely to enact their willingness to switch into actual exit behavior when they experience process failure than outcome failure.

Academic contributions

We now highlight the academic contributions of this study. First, given the lack of empirical research in this area, the most important contribution comes from the investigation of the gap between SI and switching behavior in the domain of service failure and recovery. The inconsistent academic evidence for this phenomenon has made it challenging to develop relevant managerial implications. By measuring the explanatory power of SI for switching behavior, we confirmed the weakness of this connection and the ultimate presence of an intention-behavior gap in the context of service failure and recovery. Furthermore, we showed that only a relatively small proportion of customers who stated a high intention to switch actually exited the service provider, consistent with Wirtz *et al.* (2014).

Second, most researchers focused on customer maintenance as evidenced by the measure of positive customer intentions (e.g. intention to purchase a product/service) or customer loyalty to a service provider as the outcome variables of relationship marketing, including complaint management (Gummerus *et al.*, 2017). Few have focused on customer defection or customer exit. Understanding the root causes and consequences of customer exit is as important as or even more important than loyalty (Reichheld, 1996; Stewart, 1998a, 1998b), but it has received much less attention academically and managerially. We addressed this

gap by primarily focusing on customer exit as the ultimate behavioral outcome variable and SI, FS and SRS as antecedents, as well as the potential moderating roles of FS and SRS in the relationship between SI and customer exit.

Third, while exploring the magnitude of the SI-behavior gap, we further integrated the customer characteristic of gender (female vs male) and the nature of the failure experience in terms of the failure type (outcome vs process). By showing a smaller gap in SI and behavior in the cases of female (vs male) customers and those, who experienced a process failure (vs outcome failure), this study highlights that customer demographic characteristics and the type of service failure experienced are important variables to consider to better understand the relationship between SI and actual behavior in the context of service failure and recovery.

Fourth, we used panel data, surveying customers who experienced a service failure and then following up three to four months later to register their actual exit (vs no exit) behavior. Previous studies that captured both SI and customer exit relied on self-reported measures that are subject to the concern of high common method variance. This study avoided this concern by following the recommendation by [Hulland and Houston \(2021\)](#) to explicitly measure actual behaviors rather than resorting to self-reported measures.

Finally, common industries used in the investigation of service failure and recovery have typically been large in size, such as hotels ([Han et al., 2011](#); [Shin et al., 2016](#)), airlines ([Casidy and Shin, 2015](#)), telecommunication companies ([Gray et al., 2017](#); [Haj-Salem and Chebat, 2014](#); [Malhotra and Malhotra, 2013](#); [Shin and Larson, 2020](#)) and banks ([de Matos et al., 2013](#); [Santonen, 2007](#); [Stewart, 1998a](#)). Small- and medium-sized businesses have been largely ignored. We set our study in the fitness industry, which is composed of a large number of small- and medium-sized companies, to expand the understanding of the relationships among the key variables related to service failure and recovery and particularly the gap between SI and switching behavior.

Managerial contributions

The most critical managerial contribution centers on the identification of the low explanatory power of SI on customer exit. The finding that SI is not a strong predictor of customer exit has an important implication, suggesting that not every failure may turn into a customer exit, as only a third of the customers who expressed SI actually exited. Even if the different causes of the customer exit and how they affect customer exit were not examined in this study, the primary finding about the intention-exit gap indicates that service managers should not assume that those who appear to be on the verge of switching will immediately exit the service provider. We do not suggest that, based on this finding, firms should ignore those who express SI. Rather, our finding highlights that there are multiple opportunities to mitigate customer exit.

First, FS played a significant role in increasing customer exit directly and further aggravating the direct relationship between SI and customer exit. The implication of this finding is clear: managers should focus on acknowledging the service failure immediately upon occurrence to minimize the customer's subjective perception of FS. Research shows that the acknowledgement of service failure itself along with the attempt at service recovery are critical components in ensuring customer satisfaction ([Ozuem et al., 2017](#)).

Second, we identified SRS as an important factor that helps reduce customer exit directly. Thus, it is worthwhile to make efforts to mend broken relationships with customers who have experienced a service failure by offering a service recovery to restore distributional (e.g. discounts, refunds and store credits), interactional (e.g. politeness and courtesy in treatment and trustworthiness in explaining the failure) and procedural (e.g. timing and

speed of handling complaints) justice (Tax *et al.*, 1998) to decrease customer exit. However, SRS did not come as a moderator that decreases the positive association between SI and customer exit. We believe that the enhanced post-recovery satisfaction itself serves as a buffer to customer exit, which reiterates the essential role SRS plays in shaping customers' reactions following service failures.

Third, we found that female customers with high SI tended to exit more compared to those with low and medium SI, but this was not the case among male customers. Similarly, those who experienced a process failure (related to "how" the service was delivered) and had high SI exited the service provider more than those with low and medium SI. This pattern was not found with those who experienced an outcome failure (related to "what" was delivered). These results implicate the need for managers to pay more attention to females and those who experienced a process failure. It is prudent to prioritize the allocation of resources for welcoming the complaints and offering service recovery to these particular segments of customers, given that their gap between SI and behavior is small, such that they are more likely to enact their willingness to switch into actual behavior.

In summary, it is important to identify what severe failures are, avoid their occurrence and provide an adequate service recovery as soon as a service failure takes place. As each sector is unique by the nature of its service failures, service managers need to uncover the root causes of service failures in their respective industries. Moreover, rather than reactively responding to the customer complaint, striving to proactively prevent any potential occurrence of the service failure in advance would be more effective, as doing so significantly enhances customers' service experiences (Shin *et al.*, 2017).

Limitations and future research

This study is not without limitations, prompting several meaningful avenues for future research at the same time. First, the main limitation is that the data was drawn from the fitness industry only. Although fitness centers were appropriate settings for this research, extremely critical service failures are rare in this sector. Therefore, future researchers should examine whether the current research findings are observed in other service sectors, such as retail, health care, insurance and other professional services, which are more prone to serious service failures.

Second, we implemented a longitudinal design with a short-elapsed time between the two stages of data collection. Thus, it is necessary to cover a longer time period between the data collections and especially to carry out a study that involves more than two data collection phases. This will enhance our understanding of whether our findings hold true across lengthier time periods.

Third, even though we identified the intention-behavior gap, a large proportion of the variance in customer exit remains unaccounted for. Therefore, it is imperative to expand our research model by exploring the roles of other possible drivers that would help explain variance in customer exit. These might include customer inertia, "a consistent pattern of buying the same brand almost every time a consumer shops, where a brand is bought out of habit merely because less effort is required" (White and Yanamandram, 2004, p. 184); personality traits (e.g. conscientiousness, agreeableness, etc.); brand attachment; knowledge about alternatives; and externally driven factors, such as seasonality of the business, availability of the other fitness centers within proximity, exit fee for leaving and the lack of incentives and promotion.

Fourth, we did not explore the underlying mechanisms for the gap between SI and behavior, and therefore, it will be important to examine individuals' psychological tendencies, such as willingness to forgive the company or attributions of failure that might

explain the gap. Moreover, given our limited investigation of the moderators in the relationship between SI and behavior, it will be interesting to examine the role of different recovery strategies (e.g. financial compensation such as a discount on membership or the offer of free personal trainer sessions vs nonfinancial compensation such as consultation). We also expect that customer experiences with the service provider captured by the membership length or the type of membership held might serve as a moderator, such that the longer the membership length is and the more frequently the customer visits the fitness center, the more the SI and behavior gap is reduced. However, the opposite is also likely.

Finally, the recent COVID-19 pandemic crisis has significantly influenced customer expectations for service failure and recovery strategies (Ozuem *et al.*, 2021). Therefore, it will be interesting to examine whether the SI-behavior gap is substantiated during crisis versus postcrisis situations and whether high- versus low-loyalty groups demonstrate differing SI and behavior during a crisis. Moreover, recent research has shown that customer frustration and anger are different emotions, and that intentionality of the service failure is a salient appraisal for anger, but not for frustration (González-Gómez *et al.*, 2021). Given that the COVID-19 pandemic is an uncontrollable and unintentional type of crisis, future researchers might examine how such a crisis experience would affect consumer anger and customer frustration, and ultimately what their influences are on SI and customer exit.

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Appendix

Moderating roles of failure severity

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No.	Brazilian city/state	No. of residents by city*	Human development index (HDI) by city*	Year of establishment	Target market
1	Botucatu, São Paulo	149,718	0.800	2011	Upper middle
2	Porto Alegre, Rio Grande do Sul	1,492,530	0.805	2005	Upper middle
3	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2017	Upper middle
4	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	N/A	Lower middle
5	Pirassununga São Paulo	77,330	0.801	2010	Lower middle
6	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2005	Upper middle
7	Santa Luzia, Minas Gerais	221,705	0.715	N/A	Lower middle
8	Rio de Janeiro, Rio de Janeiro	6,775,561	0.799	N/A	Upper middle
9	Poá, São Paulo	119,221	0.771	2012	Lower middle
10	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2005	Upper
11	Belém, Pará	1,506,420	0.746	2013	Lower middle
12	Pouso Alegre, Minas Gerais	154,293	0.774	N/A	Lower middle
13	Diadema, São Paulo	429,550	0.757	2012	Lower middle
14	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2014	Lower middle
15	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
16	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
17	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
18	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
19	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
20	Diadema, São Paulo	429,550	0.757	2013	Lower middle
21	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
22	Rio de Janeiro, Rio de Janeiro	6,775,561	0.799	2013	Upper middle
23	Belém, Pará	1,506,420	0.746	1980	Upper
24	Macaé, Rio de Janeiro	266,136	0.764	2007	Lower middle
25	Praia Grande, São Paulo	336,454	0.754	2005	Upper middle
26	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2014	Upper middle
27	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2014	Lower middle
28	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2014	Lower middle
29	Uberlândia, Minas Gerais	706,597	0.789	1991	Upper middle
30	Salvador, Bahia	2,900,319	0.759	2002	Upper middle
31	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2005	Lower middle
32	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2008	Upper middle
33	Belo Horizonte, Minas Gerais	2,530,701	0.810	2002	Lower middle
34	Botucatu, São Paulo	149,718	0.800	1977	Upper
35	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2012	Lower middle
36	Botucatu, São Paulo	149,718	0.800	2002	Upper middle
37	Florianópolis, Santa Catarina	516,524	0.847	2001	Upper
38	São Paulo, São Paulo	12,396,372	0.805	2009	Lower middle

Note: *Instituto Brasileiro de Geografia e Estatística (IBGE), available at www.ibge.gov.br/
Source: Research data

Table A1.
Gym profile

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